

was deluged with wounded following the First Battle of Bull Run in late July, she created a civilian agency devoted to gathering and distributing items of comfort for the wounded, and worked with other relief organizations to the same end.

These efforts alone were not enough for her. For a year she lobbied the Medical Department and other governmental organizations for permission to accompany the Union Army of the Potomac and administer to the wounded on site. Finally, with the powerful political patronage of Massachusetts Senator Henry Wilson, Barton was granted leave to pursue practical nursing duties.

It was not a moment too soon. Delayed by the mud and slow-moving wagons at the rear of the Federal columns, Barton and her small entourage arrived in the middle of the Battle of Antietam. The bloodiest day of the war was Barton's first experience of treating wounded soldiers on the battlefield, coming under fire in the process. Setting up camp next to the Union field hospital at the Poffenberger Farm just north of the infamous Cornfield, she witnessed harried surgeons attempting to dress soldiers' wounds with cornhusks as the medical supplies were held up behind the lines. Instantly, Barton donated all of her carefully gathered supplies, and when night fell, she gave the surgeons her lanterns as well. Steadfastly she worked alongside them, bringing water to the wounded, preparing food in the nearby farmhouse, and assisting the surgeons. At one point she was kneeling next to a wounded soldier, giving him water, when she felt her sleeve quiver—and discovered a bullet hole. The bullet had pierced her sleeve and killed the man to whom she was ministering.

After the battle she kept on working, refusing sleep and taking little time to eat. A few days later she collapsed from exhaustion and typhoid and was taken back to Washington, delirious. Barton recovered quickly and returned to the front. She accompanied the Army of the Potomac on many major campaigns, but the Army Medical Department had been fully mobilized since 1863 and civilian volunteers such as Barton, though still welcome, could do little to augment the army's medical systems. In April 1863, she was